

Early-User Growth Playbook

Prepared for PathBinder LLC · July 2026 · How to get your first real users with no audience

The reframe. Posting to a small following and cold-DMing fail for the same reason: you own a channel but own almost no distribution on it. The model that works for a zero-audience founder is the opposite — **stop trying to build an audience and go borrow one**. Thousands of collectors already gather daily in niche Discords, collector subreddits, and forums. Embed there, be genuinely useful for a week or two, then convert your standing into **founding testers** — not "installs." This is exactly how Collectr bootstrapped an eight-figure business: value-first posts in collector forums, a Discord funnel, a fast free scanner as the hook, zero ad spend.

Do These 3 Things This Week

- 1 **Answer the "which tracker app do you use?" threads** — the ban-proof entry, because they invite disclosed devs. Start with Elite Fourum's live [Collection Tracking Apps thread](#). Post one honest comparison opening with "Full disclosure, I built one of these — PathBinder," leading with what incumbents lack (built-in P2P marketplace, one scanner across 7 TCGs, founding perks).
- 2 **Seed 20-30 nano collector creators (1k-30k)** — openers / collection-tour creators, not competitive-deck channels. Gift-first: free lifetime tier + a "Founding Creator" badge + a referral code, no strings. Build the list from Feedsport creator lists + hashtag mining (#pokemonpulls, #cardcollection, #onepiececardgame).
- 3 **Embed in 2-3 collector Discords** — join, be active a few days, then **DM a mod asking where app-sharing is allowed** before posting. Best fit: Lowpopping (~20k), r/PokemonTCG Discord (~41k), One Piece TCG (~102k).

The Full Channel Playbook (leverage, high to low)

Channel	What to do & named targets	#1 mistake to avoid
1. Niche subreddits + "what app" threads	Run ONE account; build karma 2-4 wks with zero links; modmail before promo; post only in designated threads. Best fit: r/PokeInvesting (345k), r/OnePieceTCG (178k), r/Lorcana (89k), r/pkmntcgcollections (66k). Do the 1.4M r/PokemonTCG flagship later; r/mtgfinance last.	The drive-by link drop — shadowbans you and burns your best channel. Never copy-paste the same post across subs.
2. Collector Discords	Same ask-first / disclose flow; build relationships with mods; run pull-of-the-week + value contests. Lowpopping (~20k), PKMNTCGDeals (~91k), One Piece TCG (~102k), r/PokemonTCG Discord (~41k).	Treating it as a broadcast channel instead of being a member first.
3. Micro/nano creator seeding	Gift free lifetime tier + Founding Creator badge + an audience referral perk. Ask them to try the scanner on camera. Send the gift first, ask second. Vet on 3-6% engagement.	Chasing a few big paid influencers instead of gifting many small niche ones.
4. TikTok (your own account)	3-5 short videos/week; hook in the first second ("I scanned my whole binder in 10 minutes"); lead with satisfying card content, app incidental. Follower-agnostic FYP.	Ad-style promo videos — watch-time and completion are what get rewarded, not your pitch.
5. Local game stores (LGS)	Position as a FREE app that drives foot traffic, NOT a POS. Comp staff a lifetime tier, leave a trackable-QR counter flyer with a store code, offer a free "scan your collection" night.	Pitching against their register/POS — lead with "I send my users to shops like yours."
6. Card shows (2026)	Skip the pricey booth; work the floor with a live "scan any card, instant value" demo + a show-exclusive Founding code. On-brand pick: Card Party (Dallas, Sep 4-6).	Over-spending on a booth before you know the ROI.

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7. App Store Optimization	Target long-tail ("pokemon card scanner," "tcg collection tracker"); bake keywords into screenshot captions (indexed since Jun 2025); fire an in-app review prompt right after a successful scan to hold 4.0+.	Burning your app title on the brand name instead of top keywords; ignoring the 4.0 rating threshold.
8. Product Hunt / BetaList / beta subs	VANITY — do LAST. Spikes of non-collector signups; use for landing-page/bug feedback + backlinks only. Run Product Hunt only after your Discord gives you 8-15 warm hour-one supporters.	Reading their (inevitably low) retention as a product verdict — they were never your market.

Copy-Paste Outreach Templates

Community founding-tester post

Full disclosure up front: I built this, and I am here for honest feedback, not a sales pitch.

I got tired of using one app for my Pokemon binder, another for my One Piece cards, and a spreadsheet for what I am trying to sell — so I built PathBinder: one scanner and one binder across Pokemon, MTG, Yu-Gi-Oh, One Piece, Gundam, Lorcana and Dragon Ball, plus a built-in marketplace so you can actually sell out of your collection.

Looking for 50 founding testers to shape it before it is locked in. Founding testers get a permanent badge and a free upgraded tier that will not exist after launch. In return I want the brutal version: what does your current tracker get wrong? I will ship the top requests and credit whoever asked.

Micro-creator DM

Hey [name] — your [specific set] opening where you sorted everything into the binder at the end is exactly the collector I built for. I am the solo founder of PathBinder, a card scanner + multi-TCG collection app with a built-in marketplace.

No ask attached: I would like to just give you a free lifetime Shop tier and a Founding Creator badge to try the scanner on your own collection. If you like it, a mention would mean the world and I will set up a personal referral code that gives your audience a free perk too. And if there is a feature that would make it useful for your videos, tell me and I will build it.

Local game store pitch

Hi [owner] — I am local and a regular at [store]. I run PathBinder, a free app collectors use to scan and catalog cards and check values at home. I am not a POS and I am not touching your register — the opposite: I want to point my users at real shops like yours.

Zero cost, zero workflow change: I will comp you and your staff a lifetime Shop account, leave a small counter flyer with a QR that gives customers a signup perk and tags them to your store, and if you are open to it, run a free "scan your collection" night to pull people in. You keep every bit of foot traffic. Can I leave you a few flyers either way?

Use What You Already Built (perks + product loops)

- **Frame every post as recruiting founding testers**, not launching an app. "A badge that is never available again after launch" reads as an invitation, which anti-ad communities reward.

- **Double-sided referral tied to activation** — invitee must scan/add N cards, not just sign up (raw-signup rewards invite fraud).
- **One-tap "my collection is worth \$X" share image** (branded) turns every proud collector into a free ad. [Now built into the app: overflow menu -> "Share Stats Card".]
- **A daily habit hook** — surface daily price movers + portfolio value (and a Discord price-mover bot) so people open the app even when they are not buying. "Be the home page of the hobby." [Discord daily-movers post now built.]

30-Day Sequence

Week 1 — Set the traps, no hard selling.

- Create your one Reddit account + Discord identity; join r/PokeInvesting, r/OnePieceTCG, r/Lorcana + the Lowpopping / r/PokemonTCG / One Piece Discords.
- Post the honest comparison in Elite Fourum's tracker thread (safe day-one, because it is disclosed).
- Answer value/authenticity questions everywhere with zero links (build karma).
- Ship 2 ASO fixes: keyword captions in screenshots + the review prompt after a successful scan. Build the 30-50 creator list.

Week 2 — Seed creators + soft entry.

- Send 5-10 personalized gift-first creator DMs/day; track with per-creator referral codes.
- Modmail 2-3 best-fit subs and DM Discord mods asking where you may post. Keep contributing value; no promo yet.

Week 3 — Founding-tester recruitment goes live.

- With mod OK / in designated threads, post the founding-tester recruitment (rewritten per venue, never copy-pasted).
- Follow up with every creator who accepted; ship a feature they asked for, publicly.
- Walk into 3-5 local stores with the LGS pitch. Start your own TikTok (3-5 videos).

Week 4 — Amplify what works; layer one-time pushes.

- Double down on the ONE community + creators that actually converted (per your referral data). Ignore the rest.
- Run a store demo night; capture testimonials. Line up 8-15 warm Discord members and schedule a Product Hunt launch (Tue-Thu, 12:01am PT) as a positioning test + backlink.
- Commit to one flagship 2026 show and have onboarded creators co-promote.

Prepared July 2026 for PathBinder LLC. The needle-mover is deep, consistent presence in 2-3 collector communities + creator seeding (moves 1-4); the biggest failure mode is spraying every channel shallowly. Member counts and creator names come from third-party aggregators and may be stale — re-verify before outreach. Subreddit rules must be read in-sidebar. Yield figures are order-of-magnitude; a no-audience niche app should plan for the low end.